Abul Ma'ali was defeated in the battle that followed, caught and hanged – on the day of Eid after Ramzan. (A painting shows him strung up in a public square – there is even a blackbuck among the watching crowd, looking on approvingly.)

Hakim may have taken solace in the swift justice that swallowed his mother's murderer, but his troubles were far from over.[64] Sulaiman and Haram, having been invited into Kabul, were not inclined to leave. They married Hakim to one of their daughters and redistributed most of Kabul's provinces to Badakhshani chiefs, creating such resentment among the Kabulis that, in the winter of 1564 – only months after Sulaiman and Haram had 'liberated' the city (and months before the Uzbek rebellion broke) – several Kabuli chiefs smuggled Hakim across the Indus and sent word to his half-brother for help.

Akbar was building Nagarchain, his city of ease, practising his polo and racing his dogs. As he listened to the news of the goings-on in Kabul and heard his young brother's appeal, did Akbar reflect that, but for a series of fortunate events – that he wasn't a few years younger when his father died, that he had Bairam and Maham by his side – he, too, might have suffered as his brother was suffering? Did he marvel at how the canvas of his own life was expanding by the day, across the rivers and plains of Hindustan, while the family he left behind was still squabbling over Kabul? Did he feel a pang of guilt – or even sorrow – at the brutal murder of his father's youngest wife?

There is no record of Akbar's feelings, but he did send help. That legion of great commanders in Punjab, the ataka khail, was told to escort Hakim to Kabul and take it back from the Badakhshanis. One of the clan, Qutubuddin Khan, 'distinguished for his ability and trustworthiness', was also appointed Hakim's tutor, an older, wiser head to guide the boy.[65]

Only half of Akbar's plan worked. Kabul fell to his men in an hour as Sulaiman and Haram '[d]isheartened . . . decided upon flight '; Hakim regained his home. He was less lucky with his new tutor. It turned out that Qutubuddin Khan was more interested in visiting his homeland, Ghazni, 'where he had been born and brought up', than in nurturing the prince. Having left to satisfy his homesickness as well as he could – meeting 'all his clan, and . . . all his friends . . . laying the foundations of stations,